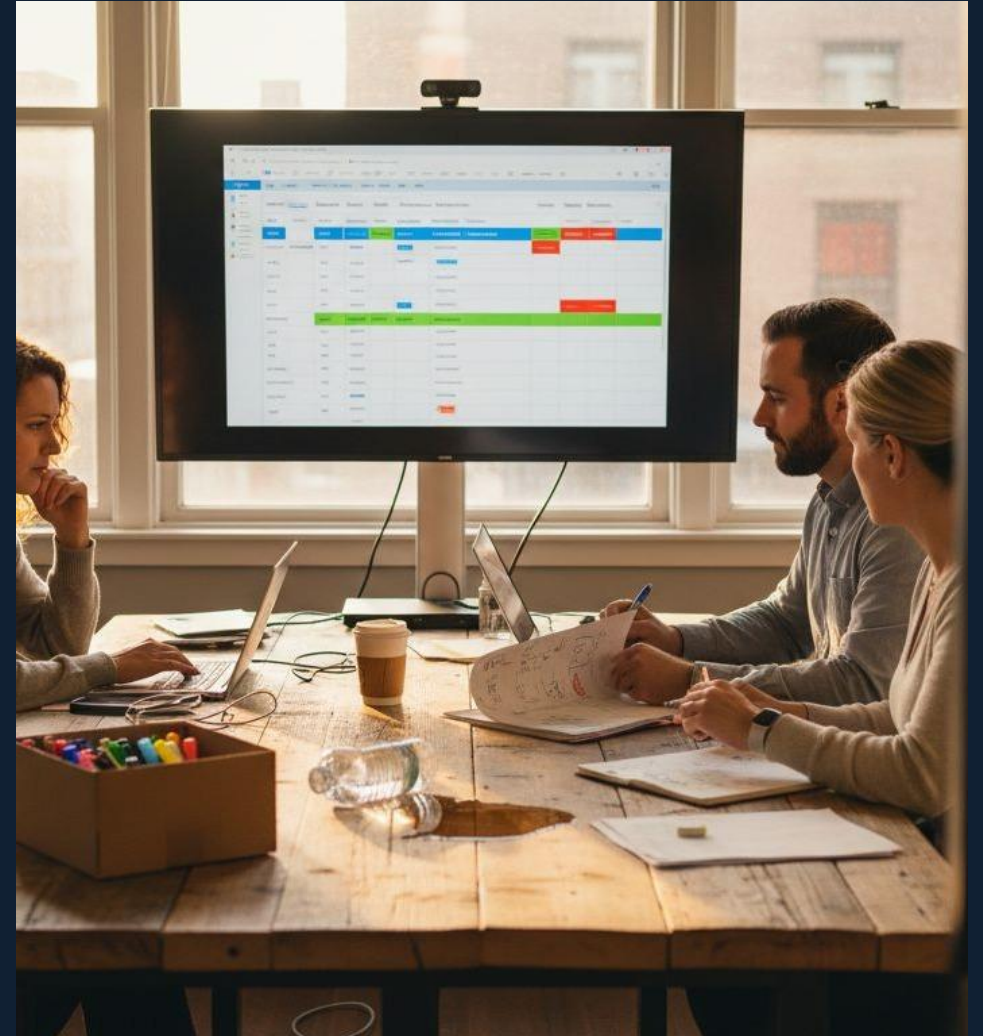


DAY THREE

Budget Development Decisions

NAIRR Accelerator • Grant Proposal Writing Cohort

Turning dollars into credible work plans,
protected time, and competitive proposals.



Budget as proposal logic

The budget should prove the project can actually happen.



Scope

Personnel

Computing

Travel

Evaluation

Dissemination

Ask: “What cost makes this scope credible?” not “What can I fit in the template?”

What to spend on first

Start with the costs that create research capacity and proposal credibility.

-  **Protected PI time** course release, summer salary, reduced overload
-  **People who produce** students, graduate researchers, postdocs, staff
-  **Data & reproducibility** curation, storage, documentation, benchmarks
-  **Coordination** meetings, travel, evaluator, partner engagement
-  **Dissemination** publication fees, conference travel, community materials

NAIRR angle

Use free or allocated computing to shift dollars toward people, training, data preparation, and publishable outcomes.

IDC, fringe, and the “real” cost of labor

Direct salary is only one part of what the award must support.

Salary / wages

What the person is paid

Direct cost

Fringe benefits

Institutional cost of benefits

Direct cost, usually a rate

IDC / F&A

Facilities and administration

Indirect cost, rate-based

Participant support

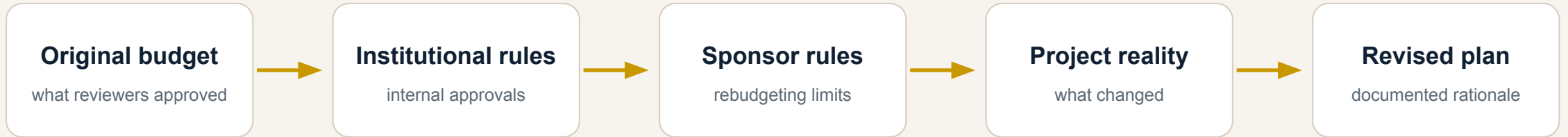
Training participants, stipends, travel

Special restrictions

Decision rule: before you promise personnel, know whether the budget absorbs fringe and indirect costs—and whether the solicitation caps them.

Budget flexibility: moving money after award

Build flexibility in, but do not assume every line can move freely.



Protect flexibility by budgeting at the right level of detail: clear enough for reviewers, not so rigid that ordinary project adjustments become impossible.

Strategies to get the most out of the budget

Maximize productive capacity, not the number of line items.

Buy time

course release or summer salary

Share infrastructure

NAIRR/TACC instead of local hardware

Pool expertise

consultants, evaluators, campus cores

Stage hiring

ramp people with milestones

Fund outputs

travel, publications, dissemination

Avoid traps

underbudgeted fringe, unallowable costs

Budget quality question: “What does every dollar make more likely?”

Hiring strategy: undergraduates, graduate researchers, postdocs

Choose personnel based on task complexity, supervision load, and timeline risk.

Undergraduates

Build pipeline; strong for data prep, pilots, reproducibility, outreach

High supervision; budget for training and continuity

Graduate Researchers

Can own technical workstreams; useful for methods and analysis

May require partner institution or subaward

Postdocs

2nd highest continuity and technical ownership; accelerates publication

Expensive; requires strong mentoring and role clarity

Research Scientist

Highest continuity and technical ownership; True partner

Most Expensive; long term relationship/partnership

The course-release decision: “How do I get out of teaching?”

Protected time must be framed as project necessity, not personal preference.

Strong justification language

PI will lead weekly research meetings

PI will supervise student/postdoc milestones

PI will coordinate partners and reporting

Release time protects the project schedule

Weak justification language

“I am too busy”

“The grant should buy out all teaching”

No connection to tasks or timeline

No departmental approval path

Budget it only if the department, dean, and sponsored programs can execute it.

Collaborative submission vs. subaward

Structure affects budget authority, reporting, review, and relationship management.

Collaborative submission

Each institution submits its own proposal package

Separate awards may be made

Each PI manages their institutional budget

Good when partners have equal intellectual ownership

Subaward submission

Lead institution submits one proposal

Partner budget is a subaward package

Lead PI coordinates reporting and invoicing

Good when one institution owns prime coordination

Budget justification: reviewers read for coherence

Justification should answer why, why now, and why this amount.

Role

Who is being supported
and what they will do

Effort

How much time is
necessary for the task

Basis

How the amount was
calculated

Timing

When the cost occurs in
the project plan

Link

Which aim, task, or
deliverable it enables

A strong budget justification sounds like a workplan with costs attached.

Live Budget Development 1

The NSF “Training-based Workforce Development for Advanced Cyberinfrastructure” Program

Live Budget Development 2

The NSF “Historically Black Colleges and Universities - Excellence in Research (HBCU - EiR)” Program

Activity: sample budget and budget justification

Create a short project scenario and produce a defensible budget.

- **Create a sample budget and justification for a funding opportunity**
- **Be prepared to share out the the program, idea, main budget items**
- **Also have 1-2 budget decisions to discuss with the group**

WRAP-UP

Budget decisions are project decisions.

Before submission, align the budget with the science, the people, the institutional rules, and the proposal narrative.

Final product: revised sample budget + one-page justification ready for mentor feedback.

